

Skills Summary

Area or Perimeter? How to Tell, and How to Find Each One

Use this reference while completing your worksheet or when studying.

Skill 1 — Perimeter: add all the way around

Perimeter is the distance around the outside of a shape. Walk the whole edge and **add** every side you walk along.

- Rectangle: long + short + long + short.
- Square: four equal sides, so add the side four times.
- A perimeter is a *length*, so it is measured in cm, m or in.

Example: A rectangle is 7 cm long and 2 cm wide. How much ribbon goes around it?

Step 1. “Around it” means we travel the outside edge, so this is perimeter — add the sides instead of multiplying them.

Step 2. Two long sides and two short sides: $7 + 2 + 7 + 2$, which is $14 + 4$. The ribbon is **18 cm** long.

Try it: A rectangle is 9 cm long and 5 cm wide. How much ribbon goes all the way around it?

check: **28 cm**

Skill 2 — Area: multiply to cover the inside

Area is how many unit squares cover the inside of a shape. In a rectangle the squares sit in equal rows, so you **multiply**.

- Rectangle: long side $\times$ short side = rows $\times$ squares in a row.
- An area counts *squares*, so it is measured in cm^2 , m^2 or in^2 .
- If your answer has no “square” in its unit, you did not find an area.

Example: A rectangle is 6 cm long and 3 cm wide. How many one-centimetre squares cover it?

Step 1. “Cover it” means we are counting squares inside, so this is area — and for a rectangle that means multiply.

Step 2. The squares make 3 rows with 6 squares in each row: 6×3 . It takes **18 cm^2** to cover the rectangle.

Try it: A rectangle is 7 cm long and 4 cm wide. How many one-centimetre squares cover it?

check: **28 cm^2**

Skill 3 — Deciding which one a question wants

Read the question for its deciding word before you compute.

- *Around, fence, ribbon, edging, border, trim* → perimeter (add).
- *Cover, fill, tiles, paint, carpet, space inside* → area (multiply).
- Then check the unit: a plain unit means perimeter, a square unit means area.

Example: A garden bed is 12 m long and 5 m wide. How much edging goes around the bed?

Step 1. The deciding word is “around”, so the question wants perimeter, not the space inside the bed.

Step 2. Add the four sides: $12 + 5 + 12 + 5$, which is $24 + 10$. The edging needed is **34** m.

Try it: A floor is 6 m long and 5 m wide and must be covered with square-metre tiles. How many tiles are needed?

check: 30 m²

(!) Watch out: The same rectangle has two different answers, one for each question — so “I got a number” is never proof you answered the right one. Two shapes can share a perimeter and still have different areas, which is why you cannot get one from the other.